Research and design direction · October 2026 · Prepared for the wellness ritual app brief

Tend: a one-minute check-in that becomes a ritual you trust.

What the brief asks for, how the leading breathwork, meditation and herbal apps answer it, where they leave a gap, and the design decisions in the accompanying prototype. The prototype is clickable and covers the conversational intake, onboarding, profile, the personalised ritual, dashboard, breath and meditation players, the herbal protocol and the journal.

Desk research from public app store listings, reviews and NIH NCCIH herb summaries. Prices are U.S. listings at the time of writing and change often. No user interviews were run for this report; section 8 proposes them.

1. The brief, read closely

A mobile-first wellness app turns a short check-in into a personalised ritual drawn from breathwork, meditation and herbal guidance. The client already has a requirements specification across twelve functional domains, an architecture blueprint, a relational data model for a governed knowledge base, a user journey and clickable HTML mockups. They want the experience refined, usability improved and polished visuals, with a serene, enjoyable feel.

The first milestone is fixed price: the design system and three core screens. Work then continues hourly.

The promise

Tell us how you are; get the right practice for right now, not a library to browse.

The hard part

Herbal guidance carries real safety risk: interactions, pregnancy, allergies. It must be governed, sourced and explained.

The feel

Serene and enjoyable, but not monotone. Calm without being a beige wall of meditation stock imagery.

2. Who it is for

The wound-up worker

30s, desk job, checks in before the laptop opens. Has five minutes, wants to feel less tight by 9:00. Bounced off Headspace because the catalogue felt like homework.

The light sleeper

Wants a wind-down routine that ends with a cup of something. Already drinks chamomile; does not know whether it clashes with her medicine.

The herbal-curious

Interested in plants, sceptical of wellness claims. Will only trust guidance that says where it came from and what it cannot promise.

Proto-personas built from the brief and competitor reviews. To be validated in the interviews proposed in section 8.

3. Competitor landscape

App	What it is	Price (U.S.)	Does well	Leaves open
Headspace	Guided meditation with a structured path	$12.99 / month, $69.99 / year	Easiest to recommend for people who do not want to browse a large catalogue; clear beginner path	Plans are course-shaped, not shaped by how you feel today
Calm	Meditation, sleep stories, breathing	Free tier; Premium varies	Strongest for sleep; includes guided breathing for stress relief	Large catalogue; personalisation is light; no herbal layer
Balance	Personalised meditation programme	$11.99 / month, $69.99 / year, $399.99 lifetime	Guides beginners through a clear path; asks questions to tailor	Meditation only; tailoring is set at onboarding, less day to day
Insight Timer	Huge free library and timer	Free, optional paid	Enormous catalogue and a flexible timer	Choice overload; no guidance on what to pick today
Othership	Music-led breathwork classes	$17.99 / month, $129.99 / year	500+ classes; daily styles (UP, DOWN, All Around); music matched to the session; 4.9 average from about 2,100 U.S. reviews	Music can drown the instructions (T3); price is the most common complaint
Breathwrk	Guided breathwork	Free tier; Pro from $9 / month	Breathwork focus rather than conventional meditation	Single modality; no reflection or herbal context
HealisticMD	AI wellness companions for natural remedies	Free with in-app purchases	Always-on companions; tracking what helps over time	States it does not provide medical advice; trust and sourcing are the open question
Herbal Natural Care	Ayurveda herb reference	App store listing	A database of herbs, uses and preparation	A reference, not a routine; no personal safety checks

What the market tells us

Gap 1 Every leader is a **library first**. Personalisation, where it exists, is set at onboarding. Nobody turns *today's* state into *today's* plan in under a minute.

Gap 2 Breath, meditation and herbs live in **separate apps**. A single ritual that sequences them, with the tea steeping while you sit, does not exist in this set.

Gap 3 Herbal apps are either references or AI companions. None we found **checks a herb against your profile** and shows its evidence level and source on the same screen.

Gap 4 Reviews keep naming **price and noise**: subscriptions feel heavy, and music-led sessions can drown instructions. Calm needs clear voice and quiet defaults.

4. Patterns to borrow, and to avoid

Borrow

- Headspace and Balance: one obvious next step instead of a catalogue.
- Othership: sessions named by the state they serve (up, down), not by technique.
- Insight Timer: a plain timer for people who know what they want.
- Calm: an evening mode that ends the day softly.

Avoid

- Streak counters that turn a missed day into failure.
- Music over instructions in guided sessions.
- Herb tips without dose, timing, cautions or a source.
- Stock landscape photos and purple gradients: they make every wellness app look the same.

5. Herbal guidance: safety by design

Herbs are the differentiator and the liability. NIH NCCIH rates chamomile in tea-level amounts as likely safe, notes that people allergic to ragweed or daisies are more likely to react, and reports preliminary evidence that it might reduce the effect of birth control pills. Secondary sources mention interactions with warfarin and cyclosporine. Ashwagandha studies are small (one 8-week trial with 58 participants). The design treats this as a rule set, not a disclaimer:

1. **Ask once, gently, at onboarding:** pregnancy, blood thinners, sleep or anxiety medicine, thyroid medicine, ragweed allergy, reflux. Stored on device. "None of these" is an explicit answer.
2. **Check before showing.** A herb whose cautions match the profile is swapped before the person sees it, and the ritual says why ("Swapped from chamomile because of your ragweed allergy").
3. **Label like an apothecary.** Every protocol shows the Latin name, part used, preparation, amount, steep time, when, how often, cautions, an evidence level in words, and the source.
4. **Claims stay modest.** "Traditionally used for" and "small studies suggest", never "treats" or "cures". This fits the client's governed knowledge base: each herb record carries cautions, evidence level and source as fields, reviewed by a qualified herbalist and clinician.

6. Design direction

Colour means place. Each practice has its own calm field, and one teal marks only what to do next.

Sky

Breath and mornings.

Sage

Herbs and the apothecary label.

Clay

Grounding and warmth.

Night

Evenings and sleep. The home screen turns to night after dark.

Paper

The journal.

Type

Instrument Serif for greetings, ritual names and the journal; Instrument Sans for everything you read quickly.

Signature moments

- **Mood as weather.** The check-in opens with "If today were weather, what would it be?": bright, steady, heavy, stormy, tired. It is quicker than a 1 to 10 scale and easier to answer honestly. The fortnight on the dashboard reads like a forecast.
- **A conversation, not a form.** Five questions, one at a time, each answered with a tap: weather, sleep, energy, what is on your mind, time available.
- **The ritual explains itself.** Every step has "Why this?", tied back to what the person said.
- **The tide.** In the breath player the whole screen fills as you breathe in and empties as you breathe out, over the real counts. No spinning circle.
- **The moon.** In the meditation player a moon fills from new to full as the sit goes on, with rain or a low hum made in the browser, and a soft bell at the end.
- **The tea steeps while you sit,** so a 9-minute ritual stays 9 minutes.

7. Proposed first milestone

Design system

Tokens (colour, fields, type, radius, motion), components (buttons, chips, weather picker, conversation bubbles, ritual step, players, apothecary label), accessibility rules: 4.5:1 contrast, 44 px targets, reduced motion.

Three core screens

1. The conversational check-in. 2. Today's ritual with explanations. 3. The breath player. These carry the product's promise; everything else builds on their components.

8. Next: validate with real people

- Five 45-minute interviews and a usability test of the check-in and ritual with the three proto-personas.
- Measure: time to finish the check-in (target under 60 seconds), share of people who start the first step, and whether "Why this?" raises trust in a herb suggestion.
- Review every herb record with a qualified herbalist and clinician before launch.

9. Open questions for you

- Which of the twelve domains and launch gates are in scope for launch, and which are later?
- Is the intake free text (a language model) or structured choices? The prototype uses structured taps for speed and safety.
- Who owns herb content review, and how often is it re-reviewed?
- Audio: recorded voice guidance, or text and ambient sound only?

Sources

- Headspace, Balance and Insight Timer comparison: breethe.com/sleep-and-meditation-app-guide/compare-evaluate/best-meditation-apps-in-2026-honest-comparisons-real-user-insights
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